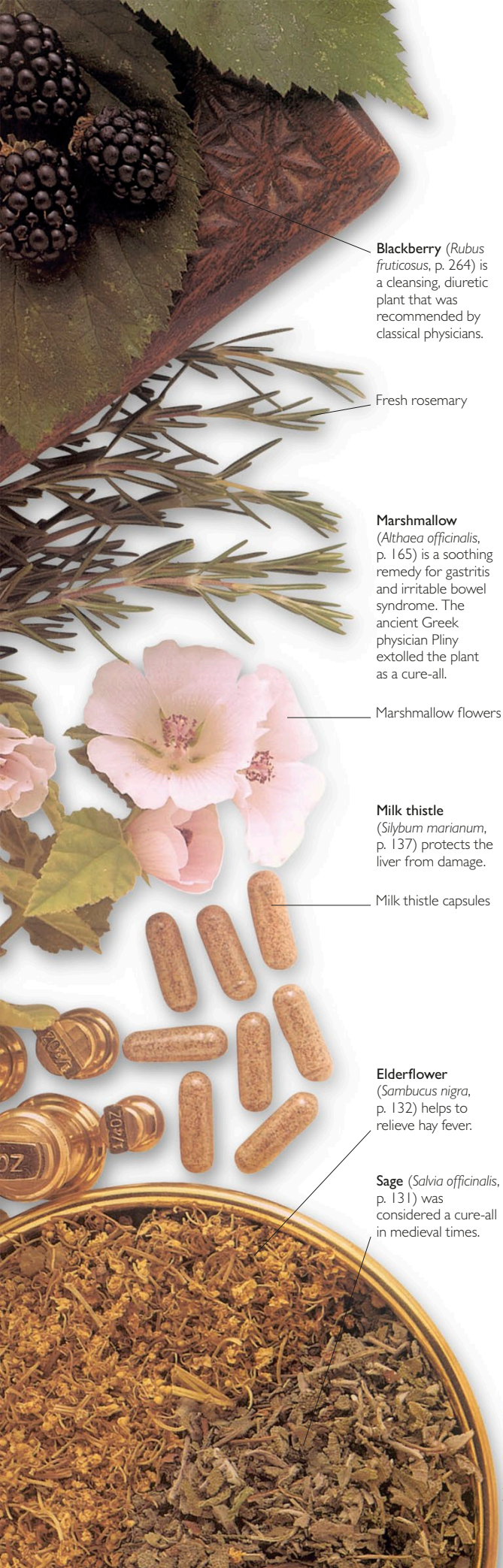




Blackberry (*Rubus fruticosus*, p. 264) is a cleansing, diuretic plant that was recommended by classical physicians.

Fresh rosemary

Marshmallow (*Althaea officinalis*, p. 165) is a soothing remedy for gastritis and irritable bowel syndrome. The ancient Greek physician Pliny extolled the plant as a cure-all.

Marshmallow flowers

Milk thistle (*Silybum marianum*, p. 137) protects the liver from damage.

Milk thistle capsules

Elderflower (*Sambucus nigra*, p. 132) helps to relieve hay fever.

Sage (*Salvia officinalis*, p. 131) was considered a cure-all in medieval times.

In some cases, the printed herbals were written by physicians, and largely reflected the writings of classical authors such as Dioscorides. In other instances they were based directly on first-hand experience—the English herbals of John Gerard (1597) and Nicholas Culpeper (1652) being good examples.

John Gerard's *The Herball* is clearly the work of a horticulturist, rather than of an herbal practitioner, but is nonetheless a mine of information. The book includes many plants that had been recently brought back to Europe by explorers and traders.

Culpeper's *The English Physitian* has been widely used as a practical reference book ever since its publication. It is a rich blend of personal and practical experience, traditional European medicine, and astrological thought. Each herb is assigned a "temperature," a use within the humoral system, and a ruling planet and star sign. Like Dioscorides' *De Materia Medica*, it has the merit of being based on close observation and extensive experience in the use of herbal medicines.

Foreign Herbs & Synthesized Drugs

The growing use of foreign herbs in the 17th century prompted heated debate about the relative value of indigenous European herbs, but for the majority of the population this was irrelevant as the imported herbs were well out of their price range. In the end, it created a rift in herbal medicine. Poor and rural peoples used locally available herbs, while affluent city-dwellers and aristocrats purchased plants of foreign origin, prescribed by university-trained physicians. By the beginning of the 18th century, approximately 70 percent of plant medicines stocked by European apothecaries were imported. Over time, this city-based herbalism evolved into conventional scientific medicine, which in turn rejected its herbal roots and regarded plant medicines as inferior.

Once conventional medicine established its monopoly of practice—in most European countries by the end of the 19th century—it became (and in many cases still remains) illegal to practice herbalism without medical certification. In Greece, traditional herbalists, known as *komboyannites*, were persecuted, and the word itself became an insult meaning "trickster" or "quack." In France and Italy, experienced traditional herbalists were imprisoned for providing treatment to their patients. The renaissance in herbal medicine that has occurred in the last 40 years offers hope that official censure will change.

Modern Practitioners

The pattern of herbal medicine across Europe today is remarkably varied, but a common thread runs through the different traditions and practices. Most European herbalists use orthodox methods of diagnosis, looking for signs of infection and inflammation, for example. However, most also try to establish a broad, holistic picture, placing the illness in the context of the patient's life as a whole. Herbalists then choose plant medicines and recommend suitable



Healers in medieval Europe frequently sought to restore physical imbalance with bloodletting, purges, and preparations that caused vomiting.